pigeons, as in any other city. But many people nevertheless imagine it to be an extraordinary place, full of gods, angels and holy stones. They believe in this so strongly that they sometimes fight over possession of the city or of specific holy buildings and sacred stones, most notably the Holy Rock, located under the Dome of the Rock on Temple Mount. The Palestinian philosopher Sari Nusseibeh observed that 'Jews and Muslims, acting on religious beliefs and backed up by nuclear capabilities, are poised to engage in history's worst-ever massacre of human beings, over a rock.'[50] They don't fight over the atoms that compose the rock; they fight over its 'sanctity', a bit like kids fighting over a Pokémon. The sanctity of the Holy Rock, and of Jerusalem generally, is an intersubjective phenomenon that exists in the communication network connecting many human minds. For thousands of years wars were fought over intersubjective entities like holy rocks. In the twenty-first century, we might see wars fought over inter-computer entities.

If this sounds like science fiction, consider potential developments in the financial system. As computers become more intelligent and more creative, they are likely to create new inter-computer financial devices. Gold coins and dollars are intersubjective entities. Cryptocurrencies like bitcoin are midway between intersubjective and inter-computer. The idea behind them was invented by humans, and their value still depends on human beliefs, but they cannot exist outside the computer network. In addition, they are increasingly traded by algorithms so that their value depends on the calculations of algorithms and not just on human beliefs.

What if in ten or fifty years computers create a new kind of cryptocurrency or some other financial device that becomes a vital tool for trading and investing – and a potential source for political crises and conflicts? Recall that the 2007–8 global financial crisis was instigated by collateralised debt obligations. These financial devices were invented by a handful of mathematicians and investment whizz-kids and were almost unintelligible for most humans, including regulators. This led to an oversight failure and to a global catastrophe.[51] Computers may well create financial devices that will be orders of magnitude more complex than CDOs and that will be intelligible only to other computers. The result could be a financial and political crisis even worse than that of 2007–8.

Throughout history, economics and politics required that we understand the intersubjective realities invented by people – like religions, nations and